

POLITY 34 - NITI AAYOG - ASCII MASTER FLOW

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PANEL 1/12 - START: LEGAL IDENTITY AND CHRONOLOGY

[15 Mar 1950 Planning Commission: executive resolution]

-> [1952 National Development Council: plan-era executive forum]

-> [2014 transition announced]

-> [1 Jan 2015 NITI Aayog: Union Cabinet Resolution]

-> [2017-18 plan/non-plan budget classification ended separately]

RULE: replacement required no constitutional amendment.

NITI = executive + non-constitutional + non-statutory + recommendatory.

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PANEL 2/12 - FOUNDATIONAL PURPOSE

CENTRAL QUESTION: how can a diverse federal polity plan without a command planner?

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+> shared national priorities with active State involvement

+> credible plans developing from village level upward

+> long-term strategy and policy/programme frameworks

+> inter-sectoral coordination and vulnerable-section focus

+> monitoring, feedback, technology and capacity building

LIMIT: broad mandate does not create binding law or exclusive jurisdiction.

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PANEL 3/12 - TWO-HUB OPERATING MODEL

TEAM INDIA HUB

State/UT engagement

cooperative federalism

shared priorities

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-> THINK -> CONVENE -> LEARN -> ADVISE

LIMIT: NITI cannot command ministries or States.

KNOWLEDGE AND INNOVATION HUB

research + technical advice

knowledge partnerships

innovation + best-practice diffusion

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PANEL 4/12 - COMPOSITION

Prime Minister = Chairperson

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+-> Governing Council:

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Chief Ministers of all States and Union Territories with legislatures

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+ Lieutenant Governors of other Union Territories

+-> Vice-Chairperson appointed by PM

+-> full-time members

+-> up to 2 rotational part-time members from relevant knowledge bodies

+-> up to 4 ex-officio Union ministers nominated by PM

+-> CEO: PM-appointed, fixed tenure, Secretary to GoI rank

+-> special invitees with relevant expertise + secretariat

TRAP: ex-officio members != special invitees != part-time members.

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PANEL 5/12 - GOVERNING AND REGIONAL COUNCILS

GOVERNING COUNCIL = apex NITI Union-State/UT development-policy forum

- > deliberation and consensus may influence policy

- > not Parliament, not Article 280, not Article 279A, not a tribunal

REGIONAL COUNCIL = specific issue affecting >1 State or a region

- > specified tenure -> concerned CMs/LGs -> PM or nominee chairs

- > experts/practitioners may be invited

TRAP: NITI Regional Council != statutory Zonal Council != Article 263 ISC.

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PANEL 6/12 - PLANNING COMMISSION TRANSITION

PLANNING COMMISSION

executive resolution

Five-Year Plan framework

central plan + resource leverage

top-down tendency

NDC plan-era forum

VERDICT: same broad legal form; different philosophy, instruments and leverage.

NITI AAYOG

executive resolution

strategy / policy framework

advisory; no former plan-allocation power

bottom-up and cooperative aspiration

Governing Council within NITI

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PANEL 7/12 - FEDERALISM MECHANISM

COOPERATIVE: State voice -> shared priority -> coordinated implementation -> feedback

SUCCESS TEST: agenda access + reasoned response + capacity + follow-through

COMPETITIVE: common indicator -> comparison -> reputation -> policy response

SAFEGUARDS: fair baseline + disclosed method + data audit + qualitative evaluation

LIMIT: consultation != State veto; ranking != causation.

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PANEL 8/12 - ASPIRATIONAL DISTRICTS AND BLOCKS

ADP (Jan 2018, district) / ABP (2023, block)

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+> CONVERGENCE of existing schemes

+> COLLABORATION across levels and field administration

+> COMPETITION through monitored progress

+> delta/change measure distinct from absolute level

LIMIT: programme != new constitutional tier; dashboard != proved impact.

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PANEL 9/12 - SDGs, DME0 AND AIM

SDG India Index -> State/UT benchmarking and localisation

LIMIT: score != legal duty, fiscal award or causal evaluation

DME0 -> attached office of NITI -> monitoring + evaluation + learning

INPUT -> ACTIVITY -> OUTPUT -> OUTCOME -> IMPACT

Atal Innovation Mission -> initiative under NITI, including tinkering/incubation tools

AIM 2.0: Cabinet-approved Nov 2024 continuation through 31 Mar 2028

LIMIT: not a statutory regulator; freeze no volatile programme metrics.

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PANEL 10/12 - INSTITUTIONAL FIREWALL

NITI: advice, strategy, convening, monitoring/evaluation support

Finance Commission: Article 280 fiscal recommendations

GST Council: Article 279A GST recommendations

Inter-State Council: Article 263 inquiry/discussion/advice route

NDC: historical executive plan-era coordination/approval forum

Ministries: policy decision, budget, rules and implementation

CAG: Articles 148-151 public audit and legislative accountability

NITI DOES NOT legislate, adjudicate, command States or allocate constitutional devolution.

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PANEL 11/12 - STRENGTHS, CRITICISMS AND REFORM

STRENGTHS: flexibility + federal forum + expertise + benchmarking + targeted focus

CRITICISMS: PM-centred agenda/appointments + no fiscal leverage + weak traceability
+ overlap + data gaming + output/outcome confusion

REFORM: State agenda route + regular Council cycle + response/action matrix

+ independent evaluation/data checks + role charters + committee scrutiny

GUARDRAIL: improve accountable soft power; do not create a super-ministry.

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PANEL 12/12 - EXAM ROUTE AND QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

PRELIMS: SOURCE -> POWER -> FUNCTION -> NEIGHBOUR-INSTITUTION FILTER

2018 GS-III: same executive status -> compare principle, method, funds, instruments

2019 Prelims route: AIM is under NITI; exact stem/key not reconstructed

MAINS PARAGRAPH: claim -> named evidence -> mechanism -> result -> qualification

CONCLUSION:

NITI replaced directive resource planning with advisory federal coordination.

Its legitimacy depends on genuine State voice, credible evidence and transparent follow-through; it must neither be dismissed for lacking coercion nor credited with powers and outcomes that belong to constitutional bodies and governments.